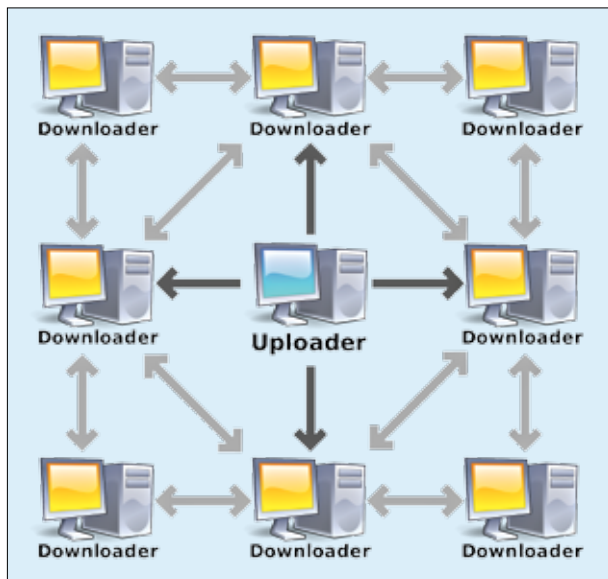


them come with a good reputation for content quality. You can also check out /r/torrents on Reddit to keep updated with the latest developments in the



A basic diagram of how Torrent downloads work

world of BitTorrent. Also check out <http://bit.ly/24RDeeZ> for a list of other torrent sites. May KAT rest in peace, we will miss it.

UNRESTRICTED ACCESS

It's not just torrents that are banned from time-to-time. Sometimes sites such as PasteBin get blocked for silly reasons. While some believe it is the right of the ISP to block whatever it feels like (depending on whether you agreed to their terms), others are firm believers in the freedom of the internet, and specifically are against ISPs blocking anything, as their job is merely to provide a connection to the internet, and not to police it. Many others would say the same about the government, and not want anyone restricting what they do online, so long as it isn't illegal. Thankfully, if you are against censorship, and your ISP or government is using technology to censor things, you can use technology to unlock their locks. Here we will look at some of the ways in which you can do exactly that.

DNS Server

Very often, ISPs are lazy and block sites using their DNS servers. This

means that when your PC requests the IP address of a site (say, pastebin.com) the ISP's DNS server has been programmed to reply with a blocked web page. If you choose to use another DNS server, such as Google's DNS servers (8.8.8.8 and 8.8.4.4), you might find that the site becomes accessible. This is because the ISP blocked pastebin.com at the DNS level, and didn't block the IP address of the pastebin.com web server. Using a different DNS service is just the easiest way to get around this type of blocking.

Proxy

If changing the DNS didn't work, you can choose to use proxies to try and access the content that's blocked. Since proxies work for FTP and HTTP services, they're perfect for browsers. You connect to a server that forwards all of your requests to whatever site you want to visit. While the request goes from the proxy server, they often pass along your IP address, so the site you're going to knows who you are (or where you are from.) This is fine when your ISP is blocking something, but doesn't work to bypass, say, geographical restrictions placed by the site you want to visit itself.

HideMyAss is an example of a popular web-based proxy. Proxies aren't very reliable though, and only the paid ones are any good. Of course, the proxy itself might be blocked by your ISP, in which case you're out of luck. Plus of course the slow bandwidth you get via proxies is made worse by all the ads that are displayed on their sites – hey, they have to make money some way, right? The biggest drawback of proxies is that you have to configure the proxy script or provide the details to each and every software of app that you have. Some software don't even have this option, and thus, it can be a bit of a hit and miss affair.

SSH Tunnels

If you are looking for a way to securely access content over the TCP protocol, SSH tunnels work wonders. You connect to a server securely with an encrypted connection, and you can also use advanced port forwarding to, say, receive port 80 browser traffic at port 8080 instead. Of course you have to have a secure shell (SSH) account on a server somewhere, and then have the technical knowledge of how to port forward and use the SSH tunnel. This is easy to find with a Google search, provided you are comfortable with SSH clients and the command line. Any decent and reliable SSH service would be paid, however, and instead of paying for this, we'd encourage you to pay for a VPN instead.

VPN

A VPN, or Virtual Private Network, is a way of bypassing pretty much all forms of blocking and censoring. What a VPN does is route all of your traffic through their network, so that no one but you (your device) and the VPN provider (server you connect to) know which sites you're visiting. As long as you can connect to the VPN service provider's server, you can connect to pretty much anything online.

For example, let's say you connected from your home in Mumbai to a VPN server in Nigeria. Now, any traffic originating from your machine will be first redirected to the server in Nigeria over an encrypted connection before it emerges online. Because most good VPNs offer encrypted connections, all that your ISP or government can see is the connection to the VPN server itself, but not the data that is being transferred, or the actual sites you are visiting. Remember though, that breaking the law can still get you prosecuted, and many VPNs have a detailed list of things you agree not to do when you join up, make sure to read that list.

There are quite a few good free options that come with both pros and cons. CyberGhost is one of the most highly recommended free VPN tools. It has a very easy to use interface and comes with a number of useful features like specifically restricting the amount of information you pass on to websites